ASSEMBLY POLLS 2022

GUJARAT / AAP

STRIVING TO MAKE A MARK

IN A MATTER OF MONTHS, AAP HAS EMERGED AS A SERIOUS CHALLENGER IN THE GUJARAT ASSEMBLY ELECTION. CAN IT DENT THE BJP IN ITS HINDUTVA FORTRESS?

By Jumana Shah in Ahmedabad



ANI

AFTER DECADES of two-party contests, Gujarat faces a triangular battle in the assembly election this time, with the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) making an aggressive play in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's home state. The BJP still retains an air of invincibility, but the ballot box can throw up surprises, as it did in 2017 when the saffron party got a scare winning just 99 seats (of the total 182), its lowest tally since 1995. This time, AAP is the loose cannon in the field. Two months ago, when the newbie party started out making promises aimed at the middle classes, it looked like it would just eat into the Congress votes. Now, with a decisive announcement on the chief ministerial face—former TV anchor Isudan Gadhvi is their man for the job—and party chief Arvind Kejriwal's unapologetic projection of AAP as a 'Hindu party', it is anybody's guess which party's vote it will cut into, if any.

Historically, Gujarat has seen mostly bipolar contests between the BJP and Congress. This is the first time a regional party like AAP is finding large-scale resonance here. Regional players like the Bharatiya Tribal Party (BTP) are restricted to a handful of tribal seats and the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) invariably contests in alliance with the Congress, limited to two seats at best. AAP has been knocking at the gates in Gujarat since 2014, but it had to wait till 2021 to finally get some traction—the party won 27 of 120 seats in the Surat municipal corporation polls.

The primary reason for AAP's rise is not just its promises (see *Kejriwal's 'Guarantees'*), but the fatigue with the BJP's *vikas* (development) narrative. Inflation, unemployment and agrarian distress are real issues, particularly after Covid-19 and the lockdowns. In a Lokniti-CSDS survey conducted in October, 51 per cent of the respondents felt inflation was a major concern while 15 per cent were worried about jobs; the corresponding figures were 11 and 13 per cent respectively in 2017. This was before the poll dates were announced and the BJP was in the middle of its Gaurav Yatra. Since then, the Morbi bridge collapse incident of October 30 has added fuel to the opposition's fire.

BJP spokesperson Yamal Vyas, though, brushes off the threat. "AAP will only eat into the Congress vote share, as the BJP voter is clear about their support for Modi. In fact, because of AAP, we will clock our highest ever seat tally this time," he says.

The BJP believes the Modi voter is still steeped in Gujarati *asmita* (pride) and will not be swayed by Kejriwal's cries of 'Jai Shri Ram' or his promises on education and healthcare, or free trips to Ayodhya's Ram temple. Their estimation is that the aspirational, urban and semi-urban middle class Hindu voters also have memories of the communal frictions from the time the Congress ruled Gujarat. But after 27 years in power, these time-tested estimates face a litmus test this time.

For instance, the size of the elector-